

The Philosophy of Ethical Selling

Ethical upselling, commission structures, and the two failure modes of undervaluing and overselling

Learning Objectives

- Distinguish ethical upselling from pressure selling
- Evaluate a commission structure for its ethical incentives
- Recognise the two failure modes of underselling your own worth and overselling unnecessary services
- Apply the recognition principle from Course VI's Module Six to product recommendations

Two ways to get selling wrong, in opposite directions

Practitioners tend to fail at selling in one of two directions: chronically undercharging and under-recommending out of discomfort with the topic of money, or overselling products and add-ons a client did not actually need, eroding the trust Module Five just taught you is the real product. This module teaches the narrow, ethical path between both failure modes.

Ethical upselling versus pressure selling

An ethical upsell genuinely serves the client — recommending the take-home kit from Course VII's Module Thirteen because it extends a result she already loves, or suggesting a longevity-focused product because her stated lifestyle genuinely needs it. Pressure selling recommends a product or upgrade regardless of genuine fit, driven by a sales target rather than the client's actual interest. The test is simple: would you make the same recommendation if there were no commission attached to it at all?

Commission structures and their incentives

A commission tied purely to retail volume, with no quality or client-satisfaction component, quietly incentivises exactly the pressure-selling behaviour this module warns against. If you employ or manage other practitioners, structure incentives to reward genuine client outcomes and repeat visits, not just the volume of any single transaction.

Underselling your own worth

The opposite failure is equally damaging: discomfort discussing money leads many skilled practitioners to underprice their own expertise, decline to mention a genuinely useful product, or absorb costs silently rather than charging fairly for them. Confident, calm pricing conversations, per Module Ten, are not aggressive — they are simply honest.

Key Terms

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[object Object]

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[object Object]

Practical Activity · Apply the Test

List three product or service recommendations you might make to a client, and apply the ethical upsell test to each — would you still recommend it with no commission attached?